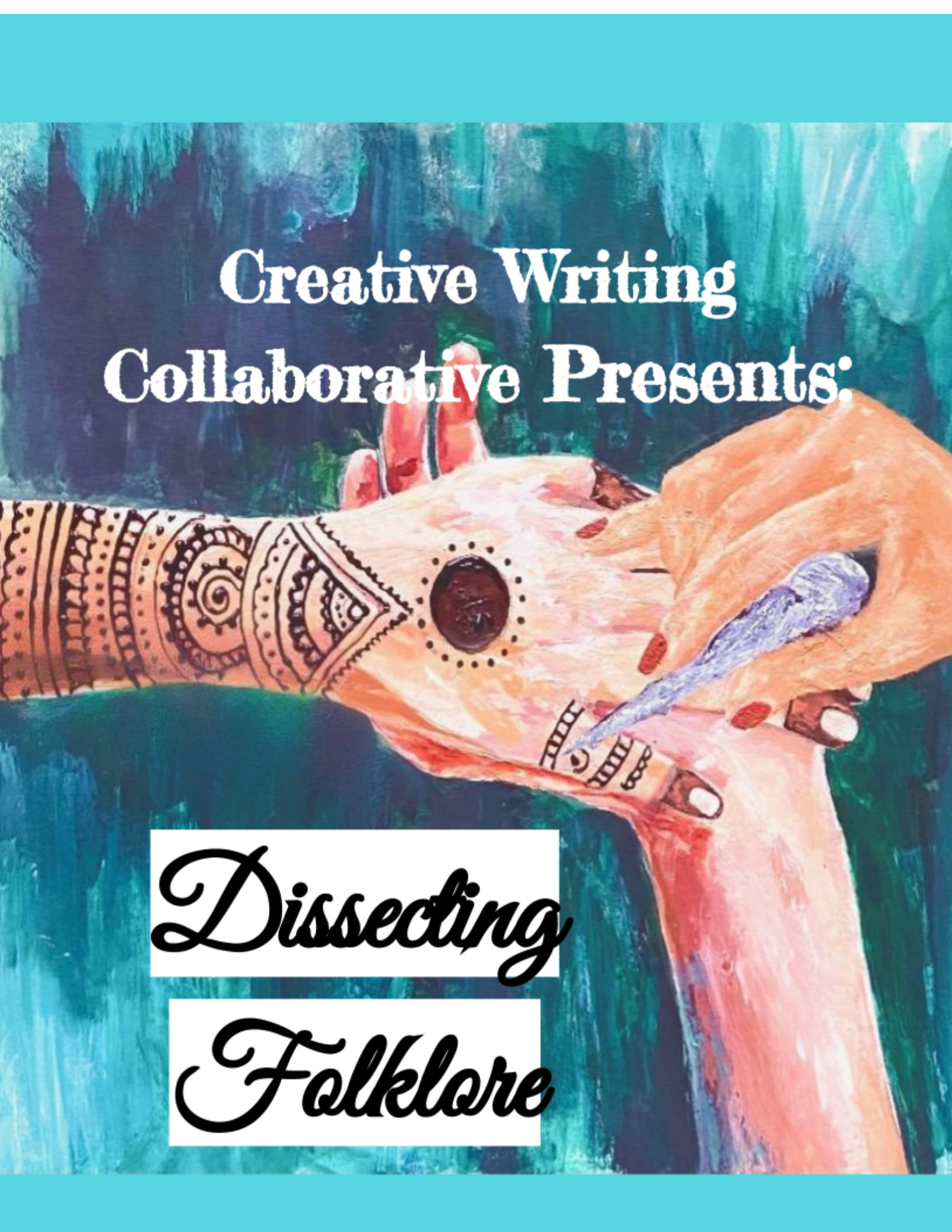


A painting of a hand with intricate henna designs on the wrist and forearm. The hand is holding a blue feather. The background is a textured, abstract mix of teal and green. The text is overlaid on the upper part of the image.

Creative Writing Collaborative Presents:

Dissecting Folklore

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What Does the Fox Say?

By: Meghna Srivarshini

We all know about animal sounds. Cow goes *moo*, pig goes *oink*, cat goes *meow*. But there's one sneaky, sly animal that always gets overlooked by their sound... a FOX! Nobody thinks about the fox, they all just assume that the fox makes some mysterious noise that people just don't hear. People all say foxes sometimes screech or howl, but nobody knows the real story behind what sound it makes...

It all started off with a fox. He was a self obsessed fox! He thought he owned the animals. The reason for this is because that fox could make every single sound in the world. The sound of a cow, a pig, a duck, a cat, an elephant, and basically any sound you can think of. He went around bragging to every animal he could find about his amazing talent.

The fact that the ox could make every sound in the forest always filled the fox with glee! He would have his usual bragging schedule and once a year he would have his annual bragging fest. Once, he was so happy that he shouted, "I'm the king of the forest!"

However, as soon as the echo of his voice slithered through the forest like a snake, a lion caught the sound and bounded through the forest trying to find this animal that threatened his leadership. *Only he could be the King of the Forest.* The lion leaped over rocks and kicked the branches out of the way. He continued for miles and finally found the fox basking on a rock taking in the sunlight. The lion was so angry that he roared so loud that miles away a bunny munching on grass scurried away in fear. It had the same effect on the fox. The fox jumped off the rock and fell flat on its face. The fox scrambled up to his feet and put on a confident face.

The lion roared, "WHO DARE QUESTION MY LEADERSHIP!"

"I do!" the fox squeaked.

"OH REALLY! THE REAL KING OF THE FOREST WOULD ROAR LOUDER THAN ME!!" the lion boasted, "ROAR!" The fox, stunned, quickly hid his fear and put on his bragging face then prepared himself for he was about to out roar the lion. The fox first bent his hind legs like he was pouncing and got ready...

“RRRRRR OOOOOOO AAAAAAA RRRRRR!” The fox roared so loud that he surprised himself and watched as the lion put on a shocked face and almost immediately retreated in fear, bounding and leaping, trying to get as far as he could get away from the fox. The fox, suddenly pleased with himself, trotted back over to the stone to keep basking, but was disappointed to see that the sun had moved on. The fox was kinda glad that the sun had moved because it was dark now and that meant that the fox could have a good night’s sleep. The fox was about to walk over to his den, but he then noticed that he had journeyed far from his den and decided to just get comfortable by the rock. The fox always thought every night to think about what new animal sounds he would make the next day. After thinking for about an hour, the fox soon got comfortable in his makeshift bed and drifted off to sleep.

“Cockadoodle doo!” the chicken that was roaming around yelled. The fox woke up a little cranky that the chicken had ruined his good night’s sleep. The fox suddenly remembered about his victory against the lion and his cranky feeling immediately drifted off. The fox was proud of himself, but the fox thought that he deserved a special treat and thought that he should go hunting. Although the fox wasn’t the best hunter, he thought very highly of himself since he would usually lure a bird in by chirping, or in other words, by mate-calling. The fox started chirping and suddenly, a female bird came elegantly fluttering down. Meanwhile, the fox got ready to pounce. The bird came flying down but in what seemed like a flash, a cat came out of the blue and caught the bird in one swift catch.

The foxes' astonishment quickly turned into anger for the cat just stole his breakfast.

“HEY! That’s my breakfast you just stole!” the fox yelled.

“Oh hello! I’m just getting breakfast. I didn’t know I was stealing yours.” the cat said innocently.

“Well you were! And that was gonna be a great breakfast, I mean look at the size of that bird!” the fox yelled in anger. The fox was angry he used his new and improved roar. The noise was so loud the cat ducked down to cover her ears.

“So you’re the fox that out-roared the lion,” the cat said mischievously.

“How do you know that?” the fox asked.

“Word spreads quickly in the forest. Especially overnight,” the cat answered. “You know what. I’ll give you half of this bird, but I will take the other half.”

“Why don’t you just give it to me whole? After all, I am the one who lured the bird in,”

“I’m only giving you half because with that kind of pounce you wouldn’t have been even close to catching this bird.” The fox was extremely irritated by the cat’s rude criticism, but he understood how bad his hunting was. He was extremely horrible at hunting since no one taught him how.

“Anywho,” the cat continued, slicing the bird in half, “I wanted to ask you a question that other animals have been asking for a while now.”

“Why don’t they just ask themselves?” the fox asked, extremely intrigued by where the cat was going with this.

“Well, let’s just say you’ve made quite an impression on the forest animals ever since you defeated the lion.” Out of nowhere, a wild dog leaped out of the protective shadows of the oak tree and glared at the cat. All it took was one glare from that dog and the brave ambitious cat turned into a small scared little kitten and bounded away leaving the half sliced bird on the ground.

“Why, what a nice lunch just waiting for me,” the dog sneered.

“What do you want?!” the fox asked, keeping his space from the dog.

“None of your business, foxy!” the dog retorted.

“Well, it is very much my business because we were in the middle of a conversation and you interrupted it! She was about to ask me a very important question!” the fox snapped back.

“As a matter of fact, it was not very important. Every animal in the forest has the same exact question.”

“What is it?” the fox asked, getting impatient.

“Why do you ask me? Why not ask any other animal in the forest?”

“Because you’re right here and it would be easier for you to tell me?”

“Well, ask someone else! I’ve got a lunch to eat and a cat to catch!” the dog responded, snatching the bird and chasing in the direction of the cat. While the dog was enjoying the foxes’ stolen lunch, the fox had bigger problems to deal with. Firstly, he lost his lunch, secondly, he had hunting skills to work on, and thirdly, the whole forest has a question about him that he doesn’t know. In the foxes’ mixed anger and confusion, he kicked sharp rock and immediately regretted it. The fox howled with pain that could be heard from miles and miles away. The fox could feel the little drops of blood dripping from the sides of his paws. The fox, as fast as he could, quickly cleaned himself up and limped back to his den before the wolves started answering back to his howls.

The next morning, the fox woke up to find mice scurrying above his den. The fox examined his paw looking for any sign of blood but nothing seemed to be very much injured. The fox set his injured paw down and, by the second, winced in pain. The fox tried again and it miraculously stopped. The fox, now getting suspicious, examined his paw again and was surprised by how easy the recovery was. The fox glanced up and was delighted to see mice still scurrying above his head. The fox would admit that this was any predator's dream to have prey just above their heads so he took most of it. The fox stretched until he was ready to pounce. The second he pounced, the mice hurried away from his den. But the fox luck just got to him and he managed to get one plump mouse. The fox feasted on his first good catch in a long time.

After the fox was done, he remembered about his previous day and all the happiness was drained from his body. The fox continued on with slumped shoulders. That was until he came across some animals in the forest. The fox thought that it would be fun to go about and start bragging about his amazing talent, knowing this would make him feel better, he started his usual bragging schedule. He bragged and bragged to all the animals until they walked away in fear and in sadness.

The fox was making all kinds of noises until he realized his daily schedule was done. As the fox was roaming the forest, boasting to any animals he saw, he didn't just boast. The fox had asked every animal in the forest about the question. But all the animals just ran away in fear, and some even refused to talk. The fox, frustrated again, was about to kick a stone but then backed up when he remembered about his previous consequences.

The fox watched up as the sun set. He felt so sorrowful since he couldn't find out the question that the whole forest was asking. He slowly walked back to his den with his head held low.

"Cockadoodledoo!" the chicken yelled. The fox was so angry at the chicken right now, he could eat it. The fox thought about this idea and accepted that that would be a great way to solve the problem! The fox slowly crept out of his den; his paws silently hitting the ground.

Once he was out of his den, spotted the chicken walking around yelling, "Cockadoodledoo!" The fox slowly crept behind the chicken, but the chicken spotted him first. The chicken started madly flapping its wings and also started to click really loud. It took the fox a couple of minutes to figure out why the chicken was clucking so loudly, but he figured it out. The chicken was calling to the other chicken and soon enough, the chicken that woke up the fox was now backed up by at least five other

chickens. The fox slowly retreated knowing that no animal can ever reason with a chicken. Not even the fox's charming talent could reason with a chicken.

The fox roamed around the forest looking for other animals to brag to until the same cat that the fox had talked to the day earlier caught the fox's eye. The cat was slowly climbing up the tree stalking a squirrel until the squirrel caught the eye of the cat and tried to quickly scamper away but the cat was too fast. The cat, in a flash of lightning, caught the squirrel in one quick blow. The cat was slowly climbing down the tree, and once she was off she caught sight of the fox and as fast as a cheetah the cat's calm little trot immediately turned into a mad run.

The fox didn't miss a beat and started to chase after the cat calling, "Wait up!"

After chasing the cat for a couple of miles the cat finally started slowing down her fast paced run and turned it into a tired jog. After a while, the cat finally fell to the ground gasping for breath and just behind the fox did the same. When both animals got back up to their feet the fox tackled the cat before she could start running again. The fox, extremely angry now, started meowing and meowing. The cat heard some words so bad that the fox's mouth should've been washed out with soap.

"WHY ARE YOU RUNNING AWAY FROM ME! I JUST WANT TO ASK YOU A QUESTION!" the fox angrily yelled.

"The dog promised me he would stop chasing me if I never told you the question," the cat squeaked.

"Let me guess, the dog told that to everybody and threatened them if they did," the fox guessed. The cat reluctantly nodded her head.

"TELL ME NOW!" the fox yelled using his loud voice.

"Everybody in the forest is asking if you can make the sound of a bunny," the cat finally admitted. But the second the cat said it, she immediately regretted it.

"What! That's the question everybody's asking?" the fox asked, confused, "But I can make every sound in the world! How come they just ask me to make the sound of a bunny?" the fox asked. After thinking for some time the fox released his clutches on the cat and dropped to the ground in laughter.

"Of course, I can make the sound of a bunny," the fox laughed.

"Then prove it!" the cat said, getting back on her paws and gaining her confidence back.

"I sure can! In fact, I'm gonna invite everybody in the entire forest! That will make me even more powerful," the fox boasted. The cat snickered at the fox's thoughts.

“What are you laughing at?” the fox snapped, obviously looking very offended.

“Oh nothing! Do you mind if I help you with your invites?” the cat asked mischievously, “After all I am on your side.”

“Yes! You must help me spread the word around!” the fox agreed.

“Just one request,” the cat said, “We must make sure the dog doesn’t come. If he does, he will kill every living animal in the forest.”

“Why does the dog not like me?” the fox asked.

“Well, in simple terms, he’s just very jealous of your talent. If you didn’t know, before you had declared yourself ‘King of the Forest’, the dog was always jealous of the lion. The dog always wanted to be ‘King of the Forest’! So, now that you are ‘The King of the Forest’, the dog is jealous of you now,” the cat explained. Once the fox completely understood the story, everything made sense now,

“So that's why he didn’t want anybody to ask the question?” the fox said.

“Yeah! But that’s not the main thing right now!” the cat said, trying to stay focused. On the inside, the cat was laughing and laughing and the fox’s know-it-all personality but tried to hide it for the cat's plan would not work if she didn’t.

“Yes! You spread the news and I will have to go find a bunny!” the fox declared. The fox was so proud of himself puffed out his chest and walked away with his head held high. The cat chuckled again by how brave the fox was acting. But the way the fox was acting just made the cat want to see his incredible failure even more!

“Cockadoodledooo!” the chicken yelled! This day the fox didn’t wake up groggily and grumpy, he woke up cheerful and ready to prove to the forest that he could make the sound of a bunny. Once the fox had his morning mouse he set out in search of a bunny. Meanwhile the cat was spreading the news about how the fox was going to fail to make the sound of the bunny. The cat told everyone the location and she also told them to bring fruit to throw when the fox fails.

The fox finally found a small bunny munching on a field of grass. The fox snatched up the bunny and was surprised that the bunny didn’t make any sound. The bunny just struggled to get out of the clutches of the fox. The fox clutched onto the bunny no matter how much it struggled but at the same time, didn’t clutch it too tight.

Once the fox went to the destination where all the animals would see his triumph he was surprised to see that many forest animals were there. Seeing how many animals were there made the fox get nervous but he pushed the feeling away and prepared himself to be the most powerful animal in the forest. The fox walked through the crown to the middle where the cat was waiting. The fox carefully set down the

bunny where the cat made sure it couldn't escape. The fox waited till the bunny was secure and he ordered the bunny to speak.

"Speak Bunny!" the fox said. The bunny stayed silent still hopping around on the grass and munching on it at the same time.

"I said," speak Bunny!" the fox ordered again, trying to stay calm. A few snickers ran through the crowd as everyone saw how the fox couldn't get the bunny to speak.

"I ORDER YOU TO SPEAK!" the fox yelled, losing his patients. The bunny still remained silent. All the forest animals rolled around in laughter as the fox stood there embarrassed. As the cat joined in on the hysterical sight she signaled the animals to start throwing the fruit. The fox got pummeled with berries, tomatoes, mangoes, apples, and other kinds of fruits. All the anger inside the animals against the fox just poured out. Some animals even shouted out what the fox did to them,

"This is for making my sister cry, and this is for always making me feel bad," and many more comments. While the animals were having the time of their lives, the fox just stood their dumb-found. Once the animals ran out of fruit to throw, they casually walked away as if nothing happened.

Meanwhile, the fox ran back to his den and scolded himself for ever trusting the cat. After scolding and scolding himself, the fox finally got tired and fell into a deep deep sleep.

* * *

The next morning, the chicken didn't have it's daily cockadoodledoo since news about the fox's failure and the animals were still laughing. This day the fox did not wake up cheerful and happy, but grumpy and mad. The fox slumped out of his den and entered the light. The fox squinted at how bright it was outside. If it had been a normal day, the fox would have had a nice breakfast and he would be on his way. The fox was walking around looking for something to eat. When the fox licked his mouth he tasted something. The fox didn't even need to think to know what the flavor was... *berries*. Just thinking about it made his shoulders sink lower. The animals threw so much fruit at him that no matter how many times he cleaned himself he just couldn't get the flavor off.

The fox was on his way to the lake to wash himself off when he remembered something. It was his annual bragging fest! If it had been a normal day, the fox would've already gone around to half of the animals in the forest showing off his talent. The fox continued on to the lake when he overheard two toads croaking to each other.

“That fox certainly got what he deserved.” the first toads croaked.

“Yes! Without a doubt. However, I wonder why the fox didn’t just go to the wise owls to solve his problems,” the other toad croaked back.

“But that wouldn’t work,” the first toad said. “If the fox asked the wise owls to speak bunny the fox would simply –” the toad was interrupted by the fox who’s curiosity got the best of.

“Who are the wise owls!?” the fox demanded. Frightened, the toads foolishly tried to hop away, but the fox was too fast for them. The fox was able to get ahold of both toads and managed to pin both down.

“I asked, who is the wise owl!?” the fox demanded again. The toad, trying to reason with the fox just squeaked,

“Well, as a matter of fact it is not just one owl, they are actually called the wise owls because there are three, –” the toad was about to keep speaking but the fox interrupted with his impatient personality.

“I don’t care! Tell me who they are, and what they do!” the fox ordered.

“Okay okay,” the toad said, trying to keep the fox patient, “The wise owls are the only of their kind to be able to grant your greatest desires. But as always, the wise owls always find a way to trick you into regretting the decision. If it wasn’t obvious there’s another catch to it. You’ve got to be very specific when you announce your wish. If anyone who wishes to go there must know, you may think the wise owls are kind to grant your wish but they are not fond of kindness, they are cruel and will try to twist your wish as much as possible. Many actually fear the owls for their unlimited power. The only good thing about the owls is that they will not torture or harass you about anything for only they will only take the foolish animals who dare to even ask an owl a wish. They are not commonly known for whoever went to the wise owls have never been seen or heard from again. Only a few who were specific with their wishes survived. In my opinion, I wouldn’t advise going there, but if you do, they live at the east edge of the forest where the apple trees grow. And also, take my advice and think about where this wish is coming from. Is it coming from the heart? Or from greed!” When the toad was done he escaped from the fox’s tight clutches and hopped away, closely followed by the other toad.

The fox just stays there thinking about his amazing triumph when he shows the cat and all those other animals that he could make the sound of a bunny. The fox followed the toads direction and went to the east edge of the forest not even thinking about the toads warning. Soon enough, the fox started seeing apple trees, tall, short,

stout, and wide. The fox kept walking till he heard a flutter of wings. The fox turned around and saw three owls perched on the nearest branch. Their bright yellow eyes bored into the fox's. Finally, all of the owls hooted in perfect unison,

"Who dares enter the wishing ground?!" the owls asked, their voices booming through the forest.

"I do not mean any harm," the fox said, backing up a step, "I was hoping you could grant one of my wishes."

"Announce your wish," the owl in the middle ordered.

"I wish to speak like a bunny!" the fox proudly announced.

"Are you positive you want to have this wish. Once a wish is done, it cannot be undone," all three owls said.

"Yes! I ask this wish with all my heart!" the fox exclaimed. The owls all did a unified head nod and started waving their multi-colored wings. Like magic, a rough wind blow rushed past the fox. When the fox turned back, the owls were gone, leaving a puddle of floating feathers. The fox bounded back to where he found the toads to thank them for their help, then afterwards have them for lunch. Once the frog reached the swamp next to the lake, he scanned it searching for the toads.

Eventually, he found one of the toads hopping from lily pad to lily pad. As the toad was hopping, the toad spotted the fox and, in less than a second, was hopping away as fast as he could.

The fox was about to call the toad to say "Hey don't go away! I wanted to thank you!" but all that came out of the fox's big mouth was a loud, horrible screech. The toad turned around, obviously puzzled by what the fox just did. Intrigued, the toad stopped hopping away and started hopping toward the fox, curious about what happened. The fox tried again but another terrifying screech came out, worse than the other one. The toad immediately understood what was wrong.

"You asked to speak the language of the bunny didn't you, to the owl," the toad guessed. The fox, confused, nodded his head.

"When you asked to speak to a bunny you weren't specific, were you?"

The fox shook his head.

"Well, serve you right! I gave you a warning, but you didn't listen!" the toad said, stating the facts. "You deserved to have lost your talent! You never used it well anyway! You should've been grateful for what you had!" the toad said. When the toad was done telling the fox what he did wrong, the toad hopped away, eager to tell everyone in the forest how the fox had lost his voice.

Time passed. One month passed, two months passed. Soon enough, a whole year had passed since the fox had made his greatest mistake. The fox now still was a vicious fox! Once he had realized what he had done, he vowed to get his revenge by eliminating every living bunny in the world!



How Did Zebras Get Their Stripes?

By: Annika Jivrajani

Beginning:

It all started on a rainy afternoon, in Cacaw, Brazil. Four white horses were sitting in their very small wooden cabin on a single wooden sofa with their legs crossed. Sasha, one of the white horses, was offering another one of the other white horses, Charles, some of her last grass. Charles was Sasha's long time crush, only Charles didn't know it.

"NO," Charles instructed, "I want finer grass, you can have that rubbish."

"Of course. I shall go and get the grass once more," Sasha sighed. She then started wobbling towards the door. The other two white horses, Matty and Motty waved goodbye, as Sasha meeped out of the door. The rain was ten times heavier than it was an hour earlier.

The white horse coughed as she passed the Great Lake.

'Hmm...' she thought. The horrible venomous snakes have been ruling for centuries... The czar isn't any better. She looked at the lake. An idea was forming in her white horse head.

SLAM!! Sasha walked into the wooden cabin.

"I have an idea!" she explained excitedly.

"I'm in!" Matty and Motty explained at the same time.

"Er, first, where's my grass?" Charles asked.

"Oh, I, um, didn't bring it."

"YOU WHAT?" Charles screamed, "Well, if that is the case, then I won't participate in this stupid idea of yours."

Sasha took a deep breath, "Fine. Let it be that way," she said.

“C’mon Matty and Motty.” Both Matty and Motty hopped to their feet. Sasha grinned. The three started their way through the front door.

“First things first, let’s establish that Charles is a jerk.”Matty and Motty snorted.

“Okay, my plan is...” Sasha whispered, explaining the plan.The next morning, the trio crept out of the cabin.

“*Ice cream, Antonio’s ice cream!*” Antonio advertised, waving his scoop in the air. Antonio Casrival was a Spanish villager. He was bald, except for his thick black mustache. His brown eyes gleamed in the sunrise. His ice cream cart was old, and the yellow paint was chipping off. Half of the ‘A’ was also chipped off.

“We would like to buy it!” Motty called.

“Good, very good!” Antonio responded. The trio was now right next to him.

“Fourteen scoops of vanilla, and fourteen spoons of black licorice,” Sasha said.

“Alright then—pay?”

“Er.....is it okay if we perform? We are sort of broke...” Matty asked. The ice cream man sighed.

“Mm..only because I favor the white horses.” The three smiled. With that, they broke into twirls, front flips, back flips, splits and a mixture of sad, happy emotions. After several minutes, they were done. Antonio clapped his hands in pleasure.

“Maravillosa!”he exclaimed. Happily, he started scooping the ice cream into several plainwhite bowls. He then proceeded to put the scoops of ice cream on Motty’s hind legs. They then neighed their way toward the lake. Then, they started plopping the ice cream into the icy blue lake. Quickly, half the lake turned black. The other half turned white.

“Done!” Sasha announced. A split second later, she was falling into the icy lake that had just turned colder because of the ice cream.

“AHHHHHHHH!” she screamed. Someone had pushed her! Angered, she swam back to shore. It was Charles!

“YOU—YOU BRAT!!”

“Haha, that’s what you get for not getting my grass!” Charles chuckled. There was then a glow thick golden light.Sasha had black and white stripes.

“UGLY!” Charles shouted.

“Actually,” Matty and Motty said at the same time, “She looks good.”

Quickly, both white horses jumped in the lake. There was another gold light.

“Zebra!” Charles calls.

“What's a Zebra?” Sasha asked, interested in the name.

“Er..” Charles thought. “Wh-what you are!” To Sasha’s surprise, she quite liked the name.

“Thanks!” she said happily. She then clapped her now black and white front paws.

“Attention all,” she started to announce to the venomous snakes who were now open mouthed and the white horses who now really wanted to jump in the lake. “All the black and white horses are now called *zebra’s*.” But the brave zebra didn’t stop there, “Also, the truth is—the venomous snakes are horrible leaders. They're cruel—they’re—they are mean and they just scare everyone with their poison,” she sighed.

“Th-think about it—we've been living horrible lives—the truth is, I would rather not live here at all and be stranded in a poisonous desert than have horrible leaders! Who’s with me?” At first there was a scilience.

“We are,” Matty and Motty said at the same time. Then more zebra’s joined. Until the only zebra or white horse was standing near the lake. And that was Charles. He stood there, his paws clutched. Then, something huge happened. A venomous snake stepped up.

“We are not actually venomous. We just wanted a home. You all can have the land if you want,” He said sadly. Sasha smiled.

“NO,” she responded boldly. “The only person who’s banned is you, *Charles*.”

“W-what—please—please Sasha—”

“No, my decision is final.”

After that, all the animals in Cacaw, Brazil lived happily. As for Charles, let's just say he's in the place he's meant to be. And that, my friends, is how Zebras got their stripes.



Why Are There Colors?

By: Jasveet Kaur

Once upon a time, in White Kingdom, there lived The Rainbow Crayon King. Even though he was a rainbow crayon, he was the king, and kings would go to jail if they tried to draw by themselves. Only the king. (Because they already have enough

power, why let them color?) In his White Kingdom, there were three kinds of crayon people: White, Black. (I wonder how hard it was to see the white people.)

“I really do wish everything was as colorful as me,” the King said sadly. Right then, there was a magical tornado.

[illegible]

“AAAAAAACHOOOO!” For some reason, when the king sneezed, he sneezed very loudly, and everything stopped. No one really knows why, so don't ask. It all started with only one sneeze, but the kingdom began to sneeze continuously, letting free many different colors.

“Achoo! Achoo! Ah-ah-ah-AAACHOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO!”

Whyyyyyyyy?!" the women sobbed as colors escaped from her mouth, "WHYYYYYYYY?!"

MEANWHILE.....

“HAHAHAHAHAHAHAHAHAHAHAHAHAHA!” the king laughed, in his empty hall, “I can’t believe it! My plan worked! My childhood dream, that dream that mother and father would never agree to, it worked!” The king exclaimed happily in his lonely, dark, empty hall. He did a little happy dance, yet even though everyone was sneezing colors, he still did not feel pleased. He wanted- no he needed more little, harmless people sneezing some colors. They were nothing. They were little specks of dust in front of the Great Rainbow Crayon King.

Then, the King knew what he wanted. He wanted to rule the world. (Silly idea, right?) As the King walked with his crayon-made legs to the picture of his mother and father, he said, “Dear parents, I promise you, I shall make you very proud of me for once. If only you hadn’t moved on. If only”, he said in a softer, and more sorrowful voice.

IN THE JUDGEMENTAL FURY:

“Who has done this misdeed? I shall not spare him,” said one of the ten members of the Wise Owl committee, in a dignified yet angry voice. (They choose kings and queens).

“Please David, don’t rush so much,” said another owl.

“But really Suzanne, you can’t blame David. This really is unacceptable”, said a third owl.

“I know this is unacceptable John, but look. Am I raging with anger like David or am I being calm?”

“I can hear you,” David mumbled.

“And you David,” Suzanne continued, “Sometimes I do believe you act like a mere child. It is not always good to be angry and want to fight someone. It’s like you get angry just at the drop of a hat.”

“I can actually, just saying,” mumbled David in a bit of a frightened voice. See, Suzanne is usually very calm, but if she’s had it, she’s had it. Everyone is scared of Suzanne’s scoldings. Basically, if you want to be happy, just don’t make her mad.

MEANWHILE IN THE KINGDOM:

“A-ah-ah-ah-Achooooooooooooooooooooooooooooo,” sneezed the people.

“Listen everyone,” the Governor said, “I think we should take this case to the Royal Court. Maybe the King can solve this big issue.”

“No, I think we are old enough to solve this ourselves,” said the Prime Minister. “We are also people with power. We can handle this.” See, Prime Minister Jack was about to become king, but James (the king right now) snatched his chance away, so Jack does have a small grudge against James.

“Now Charles (the Royal messenger), please send this message to the king: *Dear King James, the people in my humble town of Worthsburrow are in a problem. We would like to come to court so we have decided to tell you in advance your Majesty. My humble regards, Governor George.*”

“Well that is that,” said Jack, “I’m leaving. I feel like you never think about my opinion in things, and you’ll see. Without me, you won’t get any good ideas.”

IN THE CASTLE:

“Hello, your Majesty”, said Charles.

“Hello Charles. Have you got a message for me?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Here is a note from the town of Worthsburrow.” The King took the letter and read it to himself.

“*Oh no*”, the King thought.

Pitter, patter, pitter patter. SHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH.

“Oh, another rainstorm? Oh well, Charles I guess you will have to inform the “humble” people of Worthsburrow they cannot come.

IN WORTHSBURROW:

“I guess we cannot go to court today after all”, said the governor.
“ACHOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO!”

“Hey, what are those?”asked someone.

“They look like colorful plants,” replied another person.

“What is happening in this crazy kingdom?” inquired the Governor.

“I know,” said a teacher, “when we sneezed, everything became brown. Brown means soil so when it rained, these colorful plants sprouted!”

ONE YEAR LATER:

After the plants sprouted, there were colors for everything. Soon, the evil King retired and Jack became King. Everyone lived happily and had a *colorful* life (Get it? **COLORFUL?**) and they all lived happily ever after!

❀
✨ **SPOTLIGHT STORIES END HERE** ✨

Why Do We Have Clouds?

By: Mohnish Premnath

Now, what you are going to hear is not a random or playful play, and it is not part of ancient nor the modern day. It all started on a normal day in the Nile river, where the water people lived, and traveled with waterfall cars and trains that are rivers. Three Droplets (also known as triplets, for water) named Heart, Hydro, and Hop took the same form of transportation everyday. The droplets have different jobs, and need to split up: Heart goes to the water hospital and takes care of the water people; Hydro is a firefighter and puts out fire when it is a really hot day; Hop is in charge of the river train, and helps passengers to get to river stations. All of them meet at their house (a tree) at the same time.

One day, Hop mentioned, “I am sick and tired of going on the waterfall cars everyday, just to get to the river trains.” He wanted to make a new transportation that could be superb enough to travel around the entire world.

The next day, he and his brothers set out to find equipment for their new transportation. When they arrived at a stop, they saw three pathways to go through. So they did something that they had to do, **SPLIT UP!!**

Hydro whispered like a commander, “Okay soldiers, this is what we have been waiting for. We split up and find the equipment for the new transportation.” This was

the first time they had to split up in nature, and not their hometown. Hop went through the first, Hydro through the second and Heart through the third.

HOP:

Hop came to an underground tunnel, which led into two tunnels. The first stated “Africans”, and the other said “Desertians”. He went through the one with Desertians. He found himself inside a secret underground civilization. The Desert water people captured him, thinking that he was an African water person.

The leader asked, “Who are you and what brings you here?” Hop explained all about himself and his brothers, and their journey to find a new form of transportation. The leader, Mabu understood and gave him a tour of the underground village. He explained the dangers of the surface, and the animals. Hop leaped out of a cactus and the leader came to keep him safe.

Suddenly, a bird came and tried to drink them, but they escaped through the same cactus opening. Hop thanked them and left, and they gave him some soil. He went into the second tunnel of the Africans. The African welcomed him, and told him about the hole of water. They go inside it to get some oxygen and trap it with bubbles.

The African leader Babu said, “We need to depend on more water and air.” Hop acknowledged them and left with bubble oxygen and a bubble with water that the Africans gave to him. Then immediately, he heard a war, and rushed and saw the Africans and the Desertins fighting. He stopped the war and explained that they don’t need to fight.

He explained, “I saw a chain on Mabus’ neck with a picture of Babu. Babus’ neck was the same thing, but a picture of Mabu. I figured out that you were brothers, and you guys had an issue.” The brothers admitted and combined their villages to make the Baobab tree, and they rejoiced. Hop made it back.

HYDRO:

Hydro arrived in a jungle, and saw a toucan. It chased him, and he ran and led it into a tree. He was safe and sound. He continued until he arrived in the Rainforest tree village. The Rainforest people lived in treehouses to escape from the animals below, and safety trees to escape from flying creatures. Hydro marched to King Kabu, and told him the quest he is continuing right now. The king agreed and accepted his bravery, but put a test. The Rainforest people could not defeat the monkey monster that came

every week to feast on the Rainforest people, and he challenged Hydro to take on this task.

Hydro accepted the challenge and requested, “I want the longest rope you have and the biggest banana you could grow.” In one day he had a banana that was the size of the monkey itself and the longest rope made from snake skin. That same night the monkey came. The trap was set, and it captured the monkey. Then, Hydro gave the banana and the monkey never came back. The Rainforest people were grateful and gifted Hydro with some wood, and vines. Hydro journeyed back.

HEART:

Heart kept traveling until he popped out of a pond and saw sheep drinking. He also saw a water person on one of the sheep. The water person was the grasslands leader, Dabu. Dabu explained the healthy ecosystem happening as they speak. They came back to the Tree, where they lived. They helped animals when they were sick or hurt. Heart said that he did that thing back at his home. Speaking of home, he wanted to go back and he went. On the way, he saw a hurt sheep and treated it with wet grass. After some time, the sheep was better. Heart rides the sheep back to the tree. The sheep was safe, and at the end, he was given 12 bags of wool. He headed back to the meeting point.

ALL OF THEM:

They returned back and saw each other. They all were happy and headed back home. Each of them told their stories along their way home. When they arrived at their tree, They all went to sleep with exhaustion. They were as tired as bears in hibernation. The next day, they began their work. Hop used the vines as wires, wool as roof and walls, wood as seats and driving area, and mixed the soil, water and air to make a kind of fuel to make the transportation go.

When they were done building it, they announced, “Let's Name it The Cloud. It is our great great great grandfathers' name, which is Walter Cloud thanny the Seventh.” The Cloud was a giant fluffy white airplane. They started their machine but nothing happened. They tried several times, but none worked. At the end of the day, they were disappointed. All that traveling and adventures were for nothing. Hydro and Heart went to sleep. Hop kept working on it, and found the problem. One of the wine wires was not put together. He fixed that and tried for the 100th time, and it worked.

In the morning, Hop shouted, “I fixed the machine! There was a loose wire!” The other two brothers were surprised. They hopped aboard the vaporization and condensation doorway. They traveled around the world. They even stopped to help a snowflake get back to his home, in antarctica.

When they arrived back, they heard “HELP! BIG WAVE COMING!!” They drove back to the Nile river, just to see a big wave coming. They told everyone to hop aboard, and that is what they did. Once they hopped in, they flew into the sky, and they were safe. When everyone came back, they went to their same jobs, but Hydro with firefighter truck clouds, Heart with the cloud ambulance, and Hop changed his job to the cloud airport. The Water Droplets were famous for their invention, “The Cloud”, and we see clouds up to this very modern day. All kinds of Water and ice people traveling in clouds to get to their jobs, and to honor the Water Droplets.

The End.

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Why is the Ocean Salty?

By: Anika Sista

50 years earlier

“You will never stop me!” Aanya Ardverskiv cackled in delight and she continued to climb up the lava-spitting volcano. 30 feet behind her was Aditya Ray, struggling to keep up, with rocks tumbling towards him, leaving scratches on his legs. He tried to distract Aanya.

“Why are you doing this?” he asked. She didn't turn around, just kept going.

“They deserve this.” she announced coldly, “There is no need to be happy ever again and also,” she paused for a moment then smiled, fingering her skull-shaped necklace, “They need a new ruler – don’t you think?” She was nearly at the mouth of the volcano, and she ripped off her necklace, ready to drop it in.

“NO!” Aditya yelled, in last efforts to stop her from dropping it in. He ran towards her aiming for the necklace, trying to snatch it out of her hands. Suddenly, she disappeared. Aditya looked around wildly, hoping to catch a glimpse of her, anything at all.

“Invisibility is a cruel thing isn’t it?” a voice taunted. Aditya swiped at nothing but air. Aanya laughed loudly as she appeared with the necklace dangling from one

finger, the skull smiling up at her. Without fully thinking about it, Aditya ran towards the necklace, snatching it out of her hands. Before realizing what was happening, Aditya was falling into the volcano, the necklace in his hands. Aanya's eyes widened in disbelief as she stared at her hand which had once held the ever-so-precious necklace.

Then, a sudden thought occurred to her. *If the necklace went down with him into the volcano, then my plan worked. Now everyone will be sad.* She smiled to herself. She was, for the first time in days, happy. She frowned. She was happy. Why would she be happy if her plan worked? She should be sad. *If the necklace wasn't in the volcano, it's still out there* she thought, as she stamped the ground hard in defeat. Before she had time to think about what to do next, lava exploded out of the volcano and smashed right into her. Aanya cried out in pain and ran home, where her four-year-old child was waiting. She stumbled onto the ground and whispered faintly to her child, "There is a necklace hidden somewhere on the volcano nearest to our house. You must take that necklace and throw it into the volcano. Please do that for me. Please do that for me, Artris." And you could see it, the evil glint forming in his eyes, which would be the start of something terrible.

Present Time

"How much longer?" complained Angel, "My legs are going to fall off!" A couple of meters ahead, Max rolled his eyes. Typical Angel. Always exaggerating. It was a chilly October day and Max, along with his friends, Angel, Sebastian, and Alice, were hiking towards Mount Charcoal, one of the biggest volcanoes in the United States.

"Relax Angel, we've only been walking for about five minutes," Alice told her. Angel sighed but continued dragging her feet forward. When they finally arrived, they could see the huge volcano in front of them. Sebastian's eyes widened in disbelief.

"Look how big it is!" he exclaimed. The rest of his friends were in awe. Max suddenly started to frown. He pointed towards the volcano where a man with a hiking stick could be seen, searching for something in the rocks.

"What's he doing?" Angel asked loudly, her question being louder than anticipated and the man turned to face them. A scowl slowly formed on his face. He had gray eyes, as dark as a storm, and a big black hood where you could vaguely see black hair poking out. A feeling of uneasiness spread across the four friends as the man walked back down the volcano, staring at them with a wicked glare as he walked out of sight.

“That was creepy,” Alice murmured quietly.

“What do you think he was looking for?” Max asked.

“I don’t know but he seemed to be upset when we saw him,” Sebastian observed.

“Wait,” Angel said, annoyance filling her voice, “For all, we know he could’ve been just – exploring. Are we going to make this a mystery?” They all knew how Sebastian was obsessed with mystery-solving and now that there was a possible mystery to solve, he was not going to ignore it. Sebastian noticed her tone of voice and balled up his fists.

“So what if I happened to notice a few things about that person. He was pretty creepy if you didn’t notice,” he snapped. Max stepped in between them, clearly trying to stop a fight.

“Let’s just all calm down,” he suggested. Angel turned away from them, arms crossed. Alice, who’d been quiet this entire time, spoke up.

“Guys, I think you should see this,” she announced. She was crouched down near the bottom of the volcano, examining something in the rocks. They gathered around her as she picked up a necklace with a huge red ruby in the center.

“Is the ruby real?” Angel asked, her eyes widening in excitement.

“Of course it is!” Sebastian remarked as he rolled his eyes. Angel glared at him but said nothing.

“Let’s keep it! We can sell it and make, like, a thousand dollars!” Max exclaimed. Alice put the necklace on the ground and stood up,

“No,” she replied firmly, “Someone might have lost it.” She glanced at her watch, then up at the sun. “It’s getting late,” she remarked, “We should be leaving now.” And so, they walked back to their houses, Max shooting one more look at the necklace, before running to catch up with the others.

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“Mom? Can I go to the library?” Max asked later that evening. His mom blinked twice.

“The library?” she asked in surprise.

“Yeah,” Max replied. She nodded, still in disbelief, probably surprised because Max had not even once picked up a book if he wasn’t forced. Max walked two blocks, saw the library in front of him, and walked in. As he started reading, he noticed the man at the volcano staring at him from behind a bookcase but persuaded himself that it was just his imagination.

One hour later, he burst out the doors, excitement spreading across his face quicker than spilled milk on the floor. He raced home and dialed Sebastian's number, holding his breath and hoping that Sebastian would answer. He picked up on the fourth ring.

"What is it?" he asked confusedly.

"So - remember the necklace we found at the volcano?" Without listening for an answer Max continued, "Anyways, I did some research and it turns out that if you drop the necklace in the volcano, everyone will be sad - but the person that dropped it the volcano. It says how there was this person, Aanya Ardverskiv I think was her name and she stole it from this guy named Victorious Victor and attempted to throw it in the volcano. But, another guy named Aditya Ray, stopped her by stealing the necklace out of her hands and jumping into the volcano. They think he threw it over the volcano. But there was one other thing that the necklace could do. It was some special power that it contained. Nobody knows what it is though. Aanya died after that but she told her child to throw the necklace in for her. But, they don't know who her child is. The thing is, she didn't realize one thing. Whenever someone in the world cries, they won't be able to stop. And since they'll be sad forever, it won't be hard to start crying," Max finished, catching his breath. Sebastian was silent.

Finally, he asked, "How do you know that?"

"I went to the library," Max replied proudly. Sebastian laughed. Then his tone turned serious.

"Do you think that man we saw on the volcano was looking for the necklace?" he asked in a whisper. Max paused before speaking,

"Yes," he replied.

"So..." Sebastian continued in a wobbly voice, "Do we take the necklace from the volcano or leave it?" Max thought for a moment. If they took the necklace they were risking their lives. But, on the other hand, if they left it, then all happiness would be gone from the world.

"Let's take it," he decided, "Call Angel and Alice and we'll all meet at the volcano tomorrow at 11:30ish."

"All right," Sebastian mumbled dejectedly.

"So, what exactly are we doing here?" Angel asked when they approached the volcano once more.

Max glanced at Sebastian, "You didn't tell them?" He shrugged.

“Tell us what?” Alice asked curiously. Max quickly filled them in and when he finished his story they stared at him wide-eyed.

“So the necklace was important after all!” Angel exclaimed.

“Yup,” Max replied, “But we’ll have to find it again,” he added, looking at the volcano in front of them.

“What happens if the man came back after we left?” Alice asked, “*And found the necklace?*” Max pushed away that thought, leaving the question unanswered. “Let’s split up and look for the necklace,” he told them. They went in four different directions and began searching for the necklace.

For fifteen minutes they searched in the heat finding nothing until Sebastian shouted out, “I found it!” In his palm, was the necklace.

“Guys?” Angel whispered, “That man is back again.” They turned, and to their horror, the man was standing there, staring at them. He looked suspiciously at them as if trying to figure out why they were at the volcano again. Max saw Sebastian looking at the necklace in his hand as he quickly closed it into a fist. The man slowly walked towards them and the closer he got, the bigger and faker his smile got.

“Hello children!” he beamed, “I was wondering, my sister, lost this necklace – it had a big stone on it. Have you seen it?” Angel instantly glanced at Sebastian’s fist. Luckily, the man didn’t notice and continued smiling. Max glared at Angel before noticing the necklace around her neck, which, similar to the real necklace, had a ruby on it.

“Yes,” Max said, his voice ever so slightly quavering, “I think Sebastian put it in his pocket.” Sebastian looked at him, wide-eyed before realizing what Max was up to.

“I don’t have it,” he said, “I think Alice does.” Alice joined in.

“Nope. I think Angel has it, she put it around her neck – *right Angel?* Angel was confused.

“No Sebastian – oh yeah I think I have it,” she said, looking at their pleading faces. She ripped off her necklace and handed it to him. He smiled greedily and then walked away, an evil grin forming on his face.

“It won’t be long until he figures out that the necklace isn’t the real one,” Max stated nervously .

“So what do we do now?” Alice asked.

“Well first, we have to hide the necklace,” Sebastian explained, “But he’s going to come looking for us if he suspects us.”

“True,” Max admitted, “I have a secret drawer in my house though. We could hide it there.”

“Sounds like a plan,” Alice replied.

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A sudden knock on the door interrupted Max from reading Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire. *Who could it be?* Max wondered. He got off the couch and slowly walked to the door. He looked through the cracks to see the volcano man standing there with an impatient look. Max's heart stopped. He took a step back, part of him wanting to just ignore it. The other half of him got the best of him and opened the door.

“Hello!” Max said cheerfully, trying to hide the fear in his voice.

“Hello,” the man said coldly, “It appears that you gave me the wrong necklace.” Max tried to keep smiling.

“We never gave you a necklace,” he said innocently. The man looked mad.

“Lies!” he exclaimed, “You and your friends gave me a ruby necklace, did you not?”

“I - uh -” Max stammered, “Yes, I think we did. But that was the necklace we found on the volcano!”

“Yet another lie!” he snapped, “I know that you have my necklace!” Max sighed. There was no point in denying it but he stood his ground.

“I have to call Alice. I think she has it.”

“Very well,” the man declared, “I will stay here until she arrives.” Max walked over to the telephone and making sure that the man couldn't hear, he dialed Alice's, Angel's, and Sebastian's numbers, telling them about what happened. Ten minutes later, they arrived looking worried.

“Where is he?” Angel asked.

“On the couch,” Max replied.

“You let him *in your house?*” Sebastian hissed. Max nodded and he walked towards the couch where the man was sitting. He seemed surprisingly calm for someone who wanted to ruin the world. Max spoke first.

“Let me introduce you to...what's your name again?”

“Artris,” the man muttered impatiently, “Artris Ardverskiv.” *So he really is Aanya's son!* Max thought. “I believe you have something that I need,” Artris explained, “And you *will* give it to me, or else.” Alice tried to persuade Artris not to.

“If you throw the necklace into the volcano, we’ll be sad forever and once we start crying, we won’t be able to stop!” Artris rolled his eyes.

“*I don’t care,*” he snapped, “Just give me the necklace or I’ll find it myself.”

“No,” they all voiced at once. Artris smiled, then disappeared.

“Whoa,” Angel observed, “Is it just me or did he just disappear right in front of us?”

“Where did he go?” Sebastian asked, looking around. Suddenly a drawer slammed from behind them, making them all jump. Then, there was a laugh.

“Invisibility,” the voice laughed, “Been in the family for centuries.” Angel swiped at the air, her fingers touching nothing. Max closed his eyes and tried to listen for any signs of movement. By the sound of chairs moving, he could tell that Artris was in the dining room which meant he wasn’t far from the necklace.

“This way!” he called to his friends, just as they heard scraping against the wall.

“What’s this?” Artris asked, “A secret compartment?” Max froze. Artris opened the compartment to find the necklace there, the ruby as bright as can be.

“Don’t!” Max cried. But laughter followed and Artris reappeared and walked out the door.

“We have to stop him!” Angel shouted, “He’s probably heading for the volcano!” They all ran towards the volcano to see that Artris was walking up to it, very quickly. They followed him, dodging all the pieces of rock coming at them.

“It’s too late,” Angel moaned. The others didn’t reply though. They kept on going until they reached the top where Artris was standing. In his hand was the necklace, ready to throw it in.

“Don’t do it!” Max yelled. Artris glared at him.

“You can’t do anything about it. I’m going to finish what my mother started.” he growled. He dropped the necklace in the volcano.

“No!” Max yelled as he ran forward and peered inside the volcano. The necklace had not fallen directly into the lava but sat on a piece of volcanic rock. Lava was starting to form on the edge of the rock. Max took his chance and jumped in the volcano, feeling heat everywhere. He heard his friends screaming. He grabbed on a piece of rock stuck to the volcano. He could see the necklace and tried to grab it. His fingers touched the air and he groaned in frustration. He saw lava gathering on the necklace and as soon as the lava touched it, he felt gloomy and had the sudden urge to cry. Nevertheless, he grabbed the necklace and ignored his hand which felt like it was

going to explode from the lava. There was just one small mistake with his plan. *How do I get out?* he wondered. His answer was right in front of him.

“Grab on!” Sebastian yelled, as a rope came inside the volcano. He held onto the rope and was pulled up by Angel, Alice and Sebastian. The problem was that he completely forgot about the lava still on the necklace, and failed to notice his friend's sad faces or his own for that matter. He looked around him. People were crying and they didn't stop. His friends tried their hardest not to break down into tears but they finally did.

“Where's Artris?” Max asked. Alice pointed to the bottom of the volcano where Artris could be seen, on the ground, apparently knocked out.

“That was me,” Sebastian bragged, trying to show his triumph but sadness took control of him.

“We have to destroy the necklace,” Max announced.

“I don't think we can,” Alice replied quietly, trying to stop the tears running down her face. Max sighed. *I wish we could destroy the necklace* he thought, closing his eyes. When he opened them, the necklace was on the ground broken as if it was made of plastic. When he looked towards his friends, their faces were no longer sad.

“That must be the secret power that the book told us about. Anyone that holds the necklace gets a wish!” Max exclaimed.

“Well, the necklace may be broken and everybody may be happy but look around us!” Angel sighed. Max looked around. There was water everywhere, and not normal water – tears. The tears remained and no matter how hard the townspeople tried to get rid of the tears they would not budge. The tears eventually found their way to the ocean and what was once fresh clean water was now polluted with salt.



Why is Ed Sheeran's Hair Orange?

By: Mahiya Srivastava

Have you ever heard of the saying that “Carrots are good for your eyes?” Well, that saying plays a big role in this tale. Don't believe me? Wait till you read what happens throughout this chaotic tale. This tale starts with a young oblivious man

named Ed Sheeran. Now, on this fine evening Ed's brother Matthew thought of a brilliant idea.

"Ed, I triple dog dare you to....." Matthew said.

"Noo I can't do that," Ed responded

"Fine, I guess so," Ed said with a sigh.

Now what you are about to hear is the most ridiculous thing that I bet you will not expect. What Matthew told Ed was to have a carrot eating contest. For this to make any sense we have to go back in time to a hot summer day.

On that hot summer day, the sun was glistening in the sky. Meanwhile, Matthew and Ed had came back from a back race around the neighborhood. Anyhow, they went to their reigarator and the only thing that was there was a giant carrot. Ed hated carrots, but he still ate them because it was the only healthy food in the fridge . That day he ended up throwing up because that carrot was rotten and vowed never to eat carrots again.

Now in the present day, here was Ed who agreed to do a carrot contest. He was forced into doing it. As he started off with the first carrot he felt fine, but after a while his head started to hurt. His brother was speechless about what he had seen!

"Umm Ed I think you should go see yourself in the bathroom," Matthew said. Ed went to the bathroom and what he saw was crazy. Now be prepared before I tell you this next part! Anyhow Ed went to the bathroom and went to the mirror and saw that his eyes turned into the size of tennis balls.

"AAAAHHHHHHHH," Ed screamed.

"It's ok I'll take you to the doctors," Matthew told Ed in a calm voice, Matthew and Ed went to the doctors where they met Zuha, a professional eye doctor.

"Oh my gushers, you eyes," Zuha gasped.

"You are allergic to carrots," Zuha said.

Zuha took Ed to the emergency room where she got a scientist to look at Ed.

"Your hair will be at the cost of taking this medicine to help your eyes," Zuha explained.

Zuha started to give Ed the medicine but as she did his eyes started to go back to normal but his blonde hair started to turn orange. After an hour Ed's eyes were back to normal but his hair was so orange. After that experience Ed promised to think before he acted and agreed to do things.

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Why Is There Salt in the Ocean?

By: Sanjana Vijayanand

June 17th 2028 is a very exciting day for Parvathy, Bobby, and their dog Dosa. They are buying a boat-house and are going to live overseas. Right now, they are packing up their house to get ready to leave.

“Bobby, please take a shower we need to leave soon,” yells Parvathy.

“I’m going,” he screams back.

As Bobby walks out of the shower, he is wearing his finest kurta and looks all fresh. Parvathy is wearing her new sari as she puts cute, little anklets on Dosa so the whole family can look nice. All their bags are packed and they are leaving the house to move into their new boat-house.

“Are you ready to leave Bobby?” asks Parvathy.

“Yes, come we must not be late,” exclaims Bobby.

They board onto their new house. Parvathy smells the aroma of the sea as she unpacks everything so they can get settled in. Bobby goes to the kitchen to set up all the materials. The boat-house is big and has lots of space for Dosa to run around. The view of the ocean is marvelous. There are 2 bedrooms and two bathrooms, one bedroom is the master bedroom where Parvathy and Bobby will sleep. The other room is a guest room.

The next day...

Parvathy wakes up and looks over to say good morning to Bobby only to discover that he is not there. She goes to the kitchen and there he is making fresh, delicious dosas for their exciting day.

“So are you ready for today?” Parvathy asks Bobby. Today they are leaving the dock and the boat will be moving overseas, where they will see various types of animals and creatures.

“Yes, it will be so exciting to live this kind of lifestyle. Now, come eat,” says Bobby.

Parvathy sits down as Bobby passes her a dosa. She takes a first bite and in her head she thinks, “I love dosas, but Bobby added way too much salt into the batter.”

“I think I only want one dosa today Bobby,” she gags.

Minutes later, Parvathy goes to get Dosa, Bobby joins, and he goes to the steering wheel and the boat starts to move. They all sit together and enjoy the wonderful sea.

It is time for lunch. Dosa runs over to his food bowl and starts to gobble up his food. Parvathy is sitting, while watching Bobby cook one of her favorite meals. He is making chicken curry and she stares as he puts salt, salt, and more salt into the curry. Once Bobby is done they turn on their T.V and watch as they eat.

Parvathy mumbles, “This is not chicken curry, this is salty curry.” She eats a few bites then leaves the rest on the counter for Bobby. He continues to keep putting too much salt into every food they eat. In her biriyani, chi, samosas, EVERYTHING. She has had enough. The next day it was salty jalebi, the day after wasn’t any better, just the thought of salty egg curry disgusts Parvathy.

She decides she has to do something about this. One night while Bobby is sound asleep in their comfy, two-person bed, she runs into the kitchen and she hunts down every last spec of salt. She takes everything and dumps it into the ocean. That night she gets the best sleep.

The next morning... Parvathy wakes up at 5:00 a.m and she gets right to cooking come nice pooris for breakfast. For once she wants to make a nice meal without salt. Once Bobby wakes up they enjoy a nice meal together as a family. Dosa is eating his food and everyone is happy. As Bobby realizes there is no salt left in the cupboards, he finally makes meals that taste good and normal.

* * *

The boat moves slowly as Paravathy gazes at the beautiful moon with Dosa. Bobby is out scuba- diving looking at sea creatures. Suddenly, he comes across something interesting. He has been wondering where all the salt went, and he just found out. The salt was no longer the seasoning for their family’s food, but rather for the ocean...

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